



"... WOMEN HAVE BETTER UNDERSTOOD THE SPIRIT OF THE FIGHT THAN MEN."

KASTURBA GANDHI, ACTIVIST AND WIFE OF MAHATMA GANDHI

independent nations. However, in more male-dominated freedom movements women's issues were often given less priority than economic development, and the role played by women in the struggle was largely determined by the prevailing patriarchal culture of both the colonists and their opponents.

Freedom for India

Mahatma Gandhi, the leader of the Indian independence movement, referred to women as "disciplined soldiers of Indian freedom." From the 1930s, women of different classes and castes became participants in the fight for freedom, often engaged in campaigns on specific issues affecting women, such as the campaign to restrict child marriage. Kamala Nehru, the wife of Jawaharlal Nehru (an activist for Indian independence and India's first prime minister), rallied the public in a campaign of civil disobedience for which she was imprisoned in 1932.

In the Quit India Movement of 1942, which called for an end to British colonial rule, Gandhian Usha Mehta spread a message of rebellion across India via Secret Congress Radio, an underground radio station. She was arrested that year, and imprisoned for four years alongside 250 other female prisoners jailed for their activism.

700
million people
outside the UK
fell under **British**
rule during the
British Empire

Following independence, the Partition of India in 1947 led to violence with more than a million killed. Between 75,000 and 100,000 women were abducted and brutally raped.

Many women in the newly formed Pakistan were also forcibly converted to Islam. In response to these traumatic events, women in Pakistan such as Fatima Jinnah and Begum Ra'ana Liaquat Ali Khan founded organizations such as Pakistan Women's Association, which worked to improve the lives of refugees and women migrants.

African experiences

There were a great number of influential women involved in the many, diverse independence movements in African countries, both before and after 1945. In the Mau Mau Uprising of 1952 to 1964, a rebellion against British rule in Kenya, women performed a key

► Liberation at last

Algerian women cheer the arrival of independence and the end of the Algerian War in 1962. An estimated 11,000 women were involved in the conflict, some served as paramilitaries in urban centers and others joined armed guerrilla bands in rural areas.

